

You can also compare how the fund stacks up against a benchmark index (like the ASX 200 or S&P 500) to see if it's generally in line with the broader market.

One big trap new investors fall into is focusing too much on short-term performance — like who was the top performer in the last 12 months. The reality is, this doesn't tell you much at all. Markets are unpredictable in the short term, and last year's 'winner' could easily be this year's disappointment.

As a long-term Lazy Investor, you're not chasing the latest trend or quick wins. You're looking for investments that show strong, steady performance over time, without the rollercoaster of constant ups and downs.

And don't forget about fees. A fund with flashy short-term returns but sky-high fees can end up costing you more than it earns. Always check the net returns after fees to get the real picture.

The goal is simple: pick investments that align with your time frame, risk tolerance and goals, and then give them time to do their thing.

What fees really cost you

At first glance, investment fees might not seem like a big deal. You might think, 'What's one percent here or there?' But when it comes to long-term investing, even small percentage fees can quietly eat away at your returns — your money!

This is why low-cost index funds and ETFs are such popular choices. Every dollar you save on fees is a dollar that stays invested and keeps working for you. Over time, the difference can be huge.

Imagine this:

- You invest \$10 000 for 30 years and earn an average return of 7 per cent per year.
- If you paid 1.5 per cent in fees each year (which is common for some high-fee mutual funds), your investment could grow to around \$38 000. But over that time, you would have paid around \$14 600 in fees, money that could have been working for you.